

WhatsApp Cloud API — Setup Guide

Everything you need to do in Meta's console to make WhatsApp alerts work. The code is already written; this is purely the account/credential side.

Budget 1–3 business days — template approval is a human review at Meta and is the long pole. Start Step 6 first, then come back and do the rest while you wait.

What you're collecting

By the end you'll have three values to hand to Supabase:

Value	Looks like	Where it comes from
WHATSAPP_PHONE_NUMBER_ID	123456789012345	Step 3
WHATSAPP_ACCESS_TOKEN	EAAG... (long)	Step 5
WHATSAPP_API_VERSION	v23.0	fixed

The Phone Number ID is not your phone number. It's a numeric ID Meta assigns. Pasting the actual phone number here is the single most common setup mistake.

Step 1 — Create the Meta app

1. Go to developers.facebook.com and log in with a Facebook account. (This account becomes an admin of the app — use a company account, not a personal one you might lose access to.)
2. **My Apps** → **Create App**.
3. Choose the use case "**Connect with customers through WhatsApp**" — not "Other". Picking the wrong use case means the WhatsApp product isn't attached and Step 2 won't appear.
4. Give it a name (e.g. **Aurum Ops**) and create.

Step 2 — Attach a WhatsApp Business Account

1. In the left sidebar: **WhatsApp** → **API Setup**.
2. Either select an existing WhatsApp Business Account (WABA) or let Meta create one.
3. Note the **WhatsApp Business Account ID** shown on this page. You don't need it in the app config, but you'll need it in Step 5 and for support tickets with Meta.

Step 3 — Get the Phone Number ID

Still on **API Setup**:

- Meta gives you a free **test number** to start with. Its **Phone Number ID** is displayed right there.
- Copy it. That's **WHATSAPP_PHONE_NUMBER_ID**.

The test number can only message numbers you explicitly add as recipients (Step 4), and it can't be used with customers. It is fine for verifying the whole pipeline works.

Step 4 — Add a test recipient

1. On **API Setup**, in the **To** field, click **Manage phone number list**.
2. Add your own WhatsApp number, in full international format (+91XXXXXXXXXX).
3. You'll get a confirmation code on WhatsApp — enter it.
4. Click **Send message** on that page. If it arrives, the pipe works.

Do this before touching any code. If the sample message doesn't arrive, nothing downstream will either.

Step 5 — Get a permanent access token

This is the step people get wrong. The "**Generate access token**" button on the API Setup page gives you a token that **expires in 24 hours**. It's fine for the Step 4 test. If you ship it, WhatsApp alerts will work all afternoon and be mysteriously broken tomorrow morning.

For a token that doesn't expire:

1. Go to business.facebook.com/settings (Business Settings).
2. **Users** → **System Users** → **Add**.
 - Name: `aurum-ops-worker`
 - Role: **Admin**
3. Select the new system user → **Assign Assets**.
 - Asset type: **Apps** → pick your app → enable **Full control**.
 - Assign again: **WhatsApp Accounts** → pick your WABA → enable **Full control**.
 - Both assignments are required. Missing the WABA one produces a token that authenticates but returns a permissions error on send.
4. Click **Generate new token**.
 - App: your app
 - Token expiration: **Never**
 - Permissions — tick exactly these three:
 - `whatsapp_business_messaging`
 - `whatsapp_business_management`
 - `business_management`
5. **Copy the token now**. Meta shows it once and never again.

That's `WHATSAPP_ACCESS_TOKEN`.

Step 6 — Create the message templates

Start this first if you can — approval takes 1–3 business days.

Business-initiated messages (which ours are — nobody messaged us first) can only be sent using a **pre-approved template**. Free-form text is rejected outright with error `131047`.

Go to business.facebook.com/wa/manage/message-templates → **Create template**.

Template 1

- **Name:** `aurum_new_booking_alert`
- **Category: Utility** ← not Marketing. Utility is correct for transactional operational alerts, is billed at a lower rate, and is far less likely to be rejected.
- **Language:** English
- **Body:**

```
Aurum Ops: new booking {{1}} submitted by {{2}}.  
Customer: {{3}}  
Unit: {{4}}  
Value: {{5}}  
Awaiting accountant verification.
```

- **Sample values** (Meta requires these to review it):
`RM2501042, Ravi Kumar, Anita Sharma, Aurum Heights / A-1204, Rs 1,25,00,000`

Template 2

- **Name:** `aurum_new_payment_alert`
- **Category: Utility**
- **Language:** English
- **Body:**

```
Aurum Ops: new payment on booking {{1}}.  
Amount: {{2}}  
Mode: {{3}}  
Added by: {{4}}  
Remaining balance: {{5}}  
Awaiting verification.
```

- **Sample values:** `RM2501042, Rs 5,00,000, Bank Transfer, Ravi Kumar, Rs 20,00,000`

Rules that get templates rejected

- A template body **cannot start or end with a variable**. Both of ours start with "Aurum Ops:" — keep it that way.
- Variables must be numbered sequentially from `{{1}}` with no gaps.
- **The number and order of variables must match the code exactly.** Ours are built in `lib/integrations/templates.ts` → `bookingWhatsAppParams()` and `paymentWhatsAppParams()`. Change the template body without changing that function and you get error `132000` (parameter count mismatch).
- Don't use the ₹ glyph in template variables — the code sends `Rs` instead, deliberately, because the rupee symbol is a recurring source of encoding problems in review and on some Android clients.

Step 7 — Give the credentials to Supabase

These are **Edge Function secrets**, not `.env.local`. The web app never holds them.

```
npx supabase secrets set \  
  WHATSAPP_PHONE_NUMBER_ID=123456789012345 \  
  WHATSAPP_ACCESS_TOKEN=EAAG... \  
  WHATSAPP_API_VERSION=v23.0 \  
  WHATSAPP_TEMPLATE_LOCALE=en
```

The template *names* live in the web app's `.env.local`, because they're written into the delivery row at enqueue time:

```
WHATSAPP_TEMPLATE_BOOKING=aurum_new_booking_alert  
WHATSAPP_TEMPLATE_PAYMENT=aurum_new_payment_alert
```

Step 8 — Say who receives the alerts

WhatsApp recipients are **never** auto-derived from your user list — WhatsApp is billed per conversation, and messaging someone's personal mobile without their opt-in is a consent problem. So they're explicit:

```
insert into public.notification_recipients (label, channel, destination,  
events)  
values ('Accounts desk', 'WHATSAPP', '+919876543210',  
       '{BOOKING_SUBMITTED,PAYMENT_ADDED}');
```

While using the Meta test number, only numbers added in Step 4 will receive anything.

Step 9 — Go live

1. Set `INTEGRATIONS_DRY_RUN=false`:

```
npx supabase secrets set INTEGRATIONS_DRY_RUN=false
```

2. Create a test booking in the app.
3. Check it went out:

```
select channel, status, provider, error_code, error_message, created_at  
from public.notification_deliveries  
order by created_at desc limit 10;
```

SENT with a `provider_message_id` starting `wamid.` means Meta accepted it.

Moving to your real number

The test number is throwaway. For production:

1. **WhatsApp → API Setup → Add phone number.**
2. The number must **not** currently be registered to a normal WhatsApp or WhatsApp Business app account. If it is, delete that account first and wait a few minutes — otherwise verification fails with no useful message.
3. Verify by SMS or voice call.
4. Set a display name. Meta reviews it; names that look like a generic category ("Real Estate") are often rejected — use your actual business name.
5. **Copy the new Phone Number ID** and update the Supabase secret. Each number has its own ID.
6. Complete **Business Verification** in Business Settings to lift the messaging limits (the unverified tier caps you at a small number of unique recipients per day).

Error codes you'll actually hit

The worker classifies these automatically — terminal errors stop retrying, transient ones back off (1m → 5m → 30m). They land in `notification_deliveries.error_code`.

Code	Meaning	Fix
131047	Outside the 24-hour window	Template not approved or paused. Check template status.
132001	Template not found	Name or language mismatch. Name must match <code>WHATSAPP_TEMPLATE_*</code> exactly, and the language must match <code>WHATSAPP_TEMPLATE_LOCALE</code> .
132000	Parameter count mismatch	Template body has a different number of <code>{{n}}</code> than the code sends.
131026	Not a valid WhatsApp user	The recipient number has no WhatsApp account.
131008	Missing required parameter	A template variable was sent empty.
100	Malformed request	Usually a wrong Phone Number ID, or the phone number was pasted instead of the ID.
130429	Rate limited	Transient — retries handle it.

Code	Meaning	Fix
133016	Account locked/in recovery	Check Business Manager for a restriction notice.
401 / 190	Bad or expired token	You shipped the 24-hour token. Redo Step 5.

Function logs:

```
npx supabase functions logs dispatch-notifications
```

Costs

Meta bills per 24-hour **conversation**, not per message, and the rate depends on category and country. Utility conversations in India are a fraction of a rupee each. There's a monthly allowance of free service conversations. Current rates: [Meta's pricing page](#).

At this app's volume — one conversation per booking or payment, to a handful of internal staff — this is negligible. It stops being negligible if you ever start messaging customers directly, which is a separate decision requiring recorded opt-in consent.